

Feminist Criticism: a general introduction

- One of the most significant social and aesthetic revolutions of modern times.
- Examines how literature and other cultural productions reinforce or undermine the oppression of women.
- Connected with Feminist movements (3 waves):
 - 1st wave (1848-1920): abolitionism (废奴主义) and women's suffrage (妇女参政权) (setback from 1920-1960)
 - 2nd wave: (mid-1960s -1982): legalization of the pill, the abortion, a mediocre equal pay bill (同工同酬法案), and lay bare things like sexual harassment, and domestic violence etc.
 - 3rd wave (1982 till now): full equality for black women, lesbians (shaped by race and sexual orientation)

Some important terms and notions of Feminist Criticism

- **Patriarchy (父权):** a system in which men have all or most of the power and importance in a society or group. It is the culture that privileges men over women by promoting traditional **gender roles**.
- **Gender roles are** prescribed by patriarchy:
 - Men: rational, strong, protective, decisive
 - Women: emotional (irrational), weak, nurturing, submissive
 - Ref. *The Trifles* by Susan Glaspell
- Patriarchal gender roles are destructive for men and women alike: men not allowed to cry, to show pain or fear (womanish, sissy); anger and violent emotions and aggressive behaviors are permitted, even encouraged (patriarchal manhood); The imperative for men to succeed economically has become an extremely pressurized situation. (Ref. The Father in “The Egg”, by Sherwood Anderson)
- Difference between **Sex** and **Gender** (p.323)
 - **Sex: biological** constitution as **female or male**, determined by nature
 - **Gender: cultural** programming as **feminine and masculine**, created by society (social constructionism)
 - While biology determines our **sex (male or female)**, culture determines our **gender (masculine or feminine)**. Gender refers not to our anatomy but to our behavior as socially programmed men and women.

- **Biological essentialism (生物本质主义):** view of inborn inferiority of women. It bases social inequality on biological differences; and has been used to justify and maintain the male monopoly of social power. e.g.
 - **Patriarchy is sexist.** It promotes the belief that women are innately inferior to men which has been used to justify and maintain the male monopoly of positions of economic, political, and social power.
- **Social constructionism (社会建构主义):** gender categories of feminine and masculine are constructed by society.
 - One is not born a woman, one becomes one. 一个人并不是生为女人，而是成为女人的。(On ne naît pas femme, on le devient.) (Simone de Beauvoir, *The Second Sex, Le deuxième sexe*) 《第二性》波伏娃
 - e.g. Patriarchal mind-set: girls are biologically ill-suited to mathematical studies. Women tend to be emotional, intuitive, less rational.
- **Sisterhood:** psychological and political bonding among women based on the recognition of common experiences and goal
- **Pioneering efforts to resist patriarchal ideology:**
 - Mary Wollstonecraft, *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* 《为女权辩护》(1792)
 - Virginia Woolf, *A Room of One's Own* (1929) 《一间自己的房间》
 - Simone de Beauvoir, *The Second Sex* (1949) 《第二性》

A Summary of Feminist Premises

1. Women are oppressed by **patriarchy** economically, politically, socially and psychologically; **patriarchal ideology** is the primary means by which they are kept so.
2. In every domain where patriarchy reigns, woman is “**the other**” (他者): she is objectified and marginalized, defined only by her difference from male norms and values, defined by what she (allegedly) lacks and that men (allegedly) have.
3. All of Western (Anglo-European) civilization is deeply rooted in patriarchal ideology and the reliance on male oriented thinking by educational, political, legal, and business institutions. Even the development of the Western canon of great literature, including traditional fairy tales, was a product of patriarchal ideology.
4. While biology determines our **sex (male or female)**, culture determines our **gender (masculine or feminine)**. Gender refers not to our anatomy but to our behavior as socially programmed men and women.
5. The ultimate goal of feminism is to change the world by promoting women’s equality.

Feminist Practices (p. 324)

- **Gender studies 性别研究**
 - Sex-related writing strategies, including matters of subject, vocabulary, syntax, style, imagery narrative structure, characterization etc.
- **Marxist feminism 马克思主义女性主义**
 - Economic forces are seen to have been manipulated by patriarchal law and custom to keep women oppressed as an underclass.
- **Psychoanalytic feminism 心理分析女性主义**
 - Women's relationship to language and signification, femininity as a language of the unconscious that destabilizes sexual categories.
- **Minority feminist criticism 少数族裔女性批评**
 - Black feminism and lesbian feminism